

If you get stuck

Open this if any of the following is true:

- It is the 15-minute checkpoint and you still cannot say which wine and which channel.
- You have a lot of text from Copilot and no decision.
- **Your numbers do not reconcile and you cannot see where.**
- Your team is arguing and nobody can prove anything.
- There are 30 minutes left and you have nothing to hand in.

There is a rescue plan for each of those at the end. The arithmetic is in **The maths**, halfway down. Start with the method.

Where things live. Everything you need is in **your team handout** — `Handout_Team-N_<Market>.md` in the folder above this one. The company and the portfolio are in section 1, the CEO's ask in section 2, **your market in section 3, the Data Pack in section 4** (stock available in 4.2, your price-ladder inputs in 4.3), the deliverables in sections 5 and 9.

The method: five questions, in this order

The order matters more than anything else in this guide. Most teams get stuck because they start at question three.

1. What do the numbers allow?

Do not decide anything yet. Calculate first.

Take all three wines. For each one, work out the contribution per bottle, then how many bottles you would need to sell to recover the €120,000. Do it before you have any opinion about your market.

You will usually find that **at least one option is arithmetically impossible and at least one is far better than it looks**. That single table eliminates most of the argument in your team, because it replaces opinion with a constraint.

"Using only the Data Pack, calculate for each of our three wines: contribution per bottle after variable cost and export cost, and the number of bottles needed to recover €120,000. Show the formula. One table."

Then ask the question most teams never ask: does the board's 25,000-bottle target actually work with the wine you were about to choose? Elena's targets are stated in section 4.6 of your handout as ambitions, not facts. You are allowed to tell her she is wrong. You are expected to.

2. What does the brief forbid?

Once you have found the most attractive option, go hunting for the reason you cannot have it.

The constraints are in your handout, but they are **deliberately in different sections**, so nothing points them out to you. The stock available for the new market is in section 4.2 (total production is in the portfolio table in section 1). The budget is in the CEO letter in section 2. Channel rules are in the market section, section 3. Copilot will not connect them for you, because each number is individually reasonable.

"Check my proposed plan against every constraint in my handout: the stock available per wine in section 4.2, the €120,000 budget, and the channel rules in the market section. List anything that is impossible or inconsistent."

If your answer survives this, it is probably a real answer. If it does not, you have just been saved from pitching something that cannot physically happen.

3. Does any single number mean something in this market?

This is where strategy actually comes from, and it is the step people skip.

Build the full price ladder to the shelf. Then **look at the final numbers and ask what they mean to a buyer in your market**, not to you. Price bands, competitive sets, what a consumer compares you against, what a channel can and cannot stock.

"Here is our shelf price in [market] for each wine. For each one, tell me what a local buyer would compare it against at that exact price, and which channel it naturally belongs in."

A price is not just an output. In every market it puts you next to somebody on a shelf or a wine list, and **who you end up standing next to is your positioning**, whether you chose it or not.

4. What is the one thing that would kill this plan?

Not five risks. One.

"What is the single point of failure in this plan? If exactly one thing goes wrong, what is the thing that takes the whole year down with it?"

Then ask when it happens. Most plans have a moment after which recovery within Year 1 is impossible. Finding that moment turns a vague 12-month roadmap into a plan with a real deadline, and it is the most persuasive thing you can say to a board.

5. How could the numbers lie to us?

This is how you choose your non-financial indicators, and it is much better than listing plausible metrics.

"In an importer-led market, how could this plan look successful on paper for twelve months while actually failing? What early signal would reveal it before the financials do?"

Whatever comes back is your most important non-financial indicator. Every market has a different way of flattering you. Find yours.

The maths: three calculations, in this order

Every figure below is invented for illustration. These are not our wines. Run yours.

1 • Contribution per bottle — your starting point

Only one export cost in the Data Pack touches the estate's own P&L: the **€0.15** compliance and labelling charge. Freight, duty, excise and VAT sit *above* your ex-cellar price, because the importer pays them (section 4.3 of your handout). They change what the consumer pays, not what you earn.

Section 4.2 reserves uncommitted stock within the estate's planned production, with no alternative Year-1 sales opportunity. Export sales do not replace domestic sales. Bottles not purchased by the importer remain in

inventory and generate no Year-1 sales contribution. Production costs still belong in contribution; uncommitted stock is not free wine.

```
contribution (CM)    = ex-cellar - variable cost - €0.15
break-even volume   = €120,000 ÷ CM
market result at V   = (V × CM) - €120,000
```

A wine at €10.00 ex-cellar costing €6.00 to make:

```
CM          = 10.00 - 6.00 - 0.15      = €3.85
break-even   = 120,000 ÷ 3.85          = 31,169 bottles
at 25,000    = 25,000 × 3.85 - 120,000 = -€23,750
```

Do all three wines before you have any opinion about your market, then **check each break-even against the stock available for the new market in section 4.2 of your handout**. A wine can have a beautiful break-even and still not exist in sufficient quantity. That is usually why the workable answer is a **mix**.

2 • The price ladder — where the markets actually differ

Same chain in every market. Only your section 4.3 numbers change.

```
1  ex-cellar price
2  + freight & insurance      → landed value
3  × (1 + import duty %)     duty applies to LANDED VALUE
4  + excise per bottle
5  × 1.30                    importer
6  × 1.25                    distributor
7  × 1.40                    retail, off-trade
8  × (1 + VAT %)             → shelf price
9  × your Data Pack rate     → local currency (EUR/JPY 165 means €1 = ¥165)

restaurant list price = step 6 × 3
```

Skip step 8 in the USA (sales tax is ignored) and in Brazil (it is already inside the 55%). Germany needs no step 9.

Two order-of-operations errors give you a table that looks immaculate and is wrong: **VAT goes on after the retail mark-up, never before. Duty applies to landed value, not to ex-cellar.**

The one structural insight worth taking into the pitch. Steps 5–7 multiply everything beneath them by **1.30 × 1.25 × 1.40 = 2.275**. Every €1 of cost added *before* the trade chain lands as €2.28 on the shelf, before VAT. So a percentage duty compounds with price, while a flat per-bottle excise is regressive and punishes your cheapest wine hardest. Both facts fall straight out of the ladder — no outside research needed.

3 • The Year-1 total — where teams confuse their own numbers

```
contribution(wine)    = bottles sold × CM(wine)
total contribution     = Σ contribution(wine)
blended CM            = total contribution ÷ total bottles sold
Year-1 market result  = total contribution - €120,000
ROI                   = Year-1 market result ÷ €120,000
break-even            = €120,000 ÷ blended CM
% of plan              = break-even ÷ planned volume
```

The Year-1 market result (also called "net result" in the materials) is the market's contribution after launch spending, not total estate profit or cash flow. Existing estate overheads, inventory financing and the future value of unsold stock are outside the exercise. ROI here is the market result relative to the launch budget, not a return on the estate's total invested capital.

Blended CM is volume-weighted, not the average of the three CMs, and it is valid for that exact mix only. Change the mix — including in every scenario — and recalculate.

Check it back: break-even $\times$ blended CM must return €120,000. If it doesn't, something upstream is wrong.

"% of plan" is the number Elena will remember. It says how much of the plan has to work to recover the launch spending on a contribution basis, not when cash is collected. Above roughly 80%, you are quietly claiming near-perfect execution — say it out loud before she does.

⚠ Revenue is not contribution, and neither one is profit. $\Sigma (\text{volume} \times \text{ex-cellar})$ is revenue. If a slide shows a large number labelled "profit", check which one it really is.

Three things that will cost you credibility

Importer and distributor margins are not your cost. They sit above your ex-cellar price, in your customer's economics. Your ex-cellar price is your revenue.

A plan can have a break-even higher than the volume it ships. It then cannot break even at all — a far sharper finding than "we make less money". Go looking for it in your downside scenario.

Do not subtract freight. Under our terms the importer pays freight, duty and excise (section 4.3 of your handout), so they belong in the price ladder, not in your contribution. If you want to argue for a different arrangement, write it down as an assumption and say it in the pitch.

Rescue plans

"We cannot agree which wine to lead with"

Stop discussing. Run question 1. The arithmetic will usually eliminate at least one option outright and the argument disappears. If two options survive, model both and compare contribution side by side, then pick the one that best fits the market section of your handout. **A decision defended with a number beats a decision defended with an adjective.**

"We have loads of output from Copilot but no decision"

You have been asking it to describe instead of to choose. Force it:

"Stop giving me options. Based on everything in this conversation, pick ONE wine and ONE lead channel for [market] and defend the choice in five sentences. Then tell me the strongest argument against your own choice."

"Our plan feels generic"

It probably is. Test it:

"Would this plan work unchanged in a different country? If yes, it is not a strategy for [market]. Tell me what is generic in it and give me one thing that is true only in this market."

Then check it against **section 3.1 of your handout**. If your plan does not answer those three questions, that is where the generic is hiding.

"We cannot think of non-financial indicators"

Use question 5. Then for each candidate ask only three things: what we measure, what good looks like at 12 months, and what we do if it misses. If you cannot say what you would *do* about it, it is not an indicator, it is trivia. Cut it.

"The deck will not build"

Do not fight the tool. Ask for the content instead:

"Give me the deck slide by slide. Title plus a maximum of five short bullets per slide, 8 slides."

Paste into PowerPoint manually — 99_Indicative-Submission_Deck.pptx in this folder gives you the eight-slide skeleton to paste into. **A plain deck delivered beats a beautiful deck that does not exist.**

"30 minutes left and we have nothing"

Do exactly this, in this order, and nothing else:

1. **(5 min)** Run question 1. Pick the wine with the best contribution that you can actually supply. Write one sentence: *"We lead with X through channel Y."*
2. **(8 min)** Get the price ladder and the break-even for that wine. One table.
3. **(5 min)** Three financial indicators, three non-financial. Target and trigger action only.
4. **(7 min)** Ask Copilot for an 8-slide deck from the conversation. Whatever comes out, take it.
5. **(5 min)** Generate one image. First result. Do not iterate.

That is a complete, defensible submission. It will not win, but it will pass, and you will have something real to talk about in the reflection.

Three questions that unstick almost anything

1. **"What am I assuming here that I have not written down?"**
 2. **"What would have to be true for this to be wrong?"**
 3. **"If I only had one number to convince the board, which one would it be?"**
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